

BOARD GAME RULEBOOK

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Game Title: Cruellest Years

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Historical Event: WWII

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1. Contents

Game Board & Map

- 1 World Map game board, divided into hexagon regions, with 41 named cities.
- 1 Territory Reference Sheet listing each territory by name and its assigned theatre (Europe, Asia, or Wider World).
- 1 City Reference Sheet listing each city by name and its assigned location.

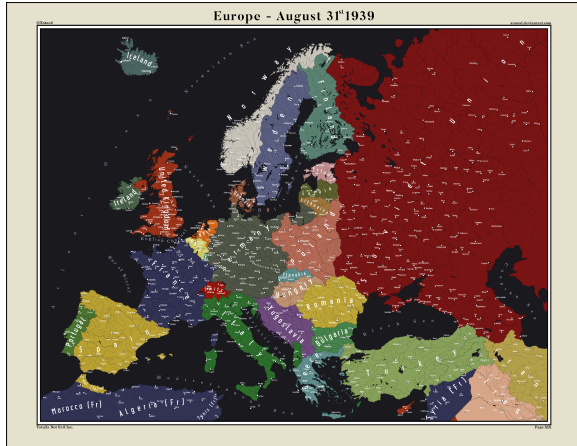


Figure 1. Game Map

National Components (per playing power)

- 18 Territorial Reference Cards, one for each playable power, showing its starting statistics and Unique Unit Trait.
- 18+ Leader Cards, between one and three named historical leaders per nation, players can choose different leaders of the same country.

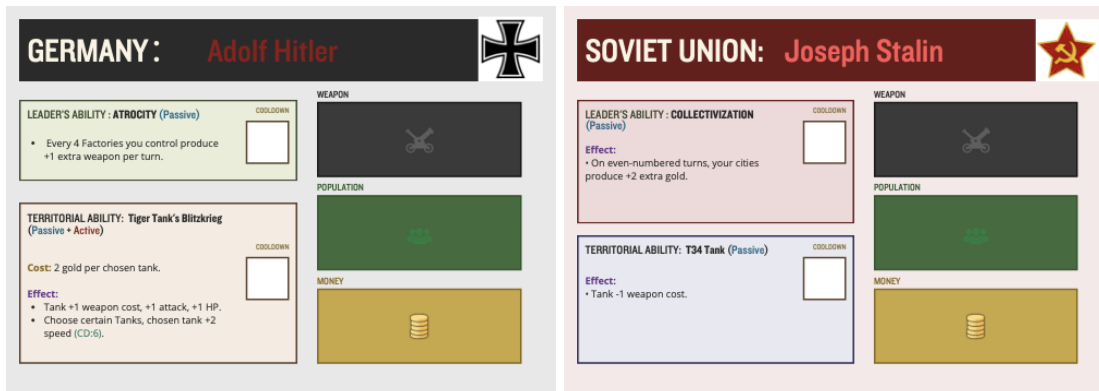


Figure 2. Territorial and Leader Cards

Military Unit Figures

Each nation has its own coloured set of figures for the nine unit types:

- Infantry
- Mechanized Infantry
- Artillery
- Tank
- Boat
- Aircraft Carrier

- Plane
- Bomber
- Anti-Aircraft Artillery

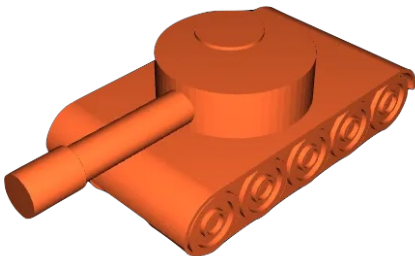


Figure 3. Military Unit Figures (Tank)

Resource Tokens

- Gold tokens (national treasury), in denominations of 1, 5, and 10.
- Weapon tokens, in denominations of 1 and 5.
- Population tokens, in denominations of 1 and 5.
- HP coins (small red markers placed beneath each unit figure to track Health Point of unit).

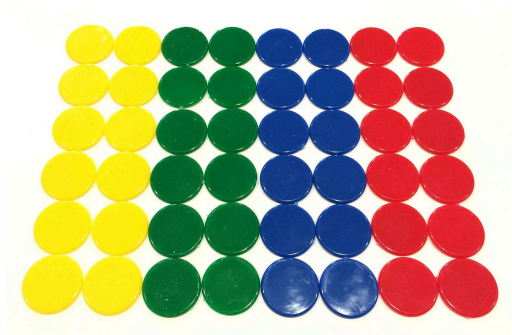


Figure 4. Resource Tokens

Map Markers

City markers

- placed on the board at game start to mark starting cities.

Factory markers

- placed on the board at game start and during play as factories are built.

Capital markers

- one per nation, designating its capital city.

Cooldown dice

- used to track active-ability cooldowns.

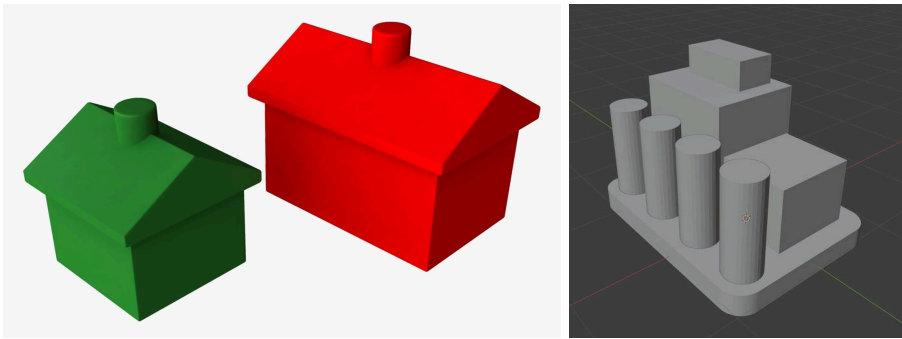


Figure 5. Map Markers

Reference Materials

- 1 Rulebook.
- 1 Military Unit Reference Sheet.
- 1 Territorial (National) Setup Reference Sheet.

UNIT COSTS							
UNIT TYPE	WEAPON	POPULATION	BLOOD	RANGE	ATTACK	SPEED	FEE
Infantry	1	1	1	1	1	2	1
Mech. Infantry	2	1	1	2	1	3	2
Artillery	2	1	1	2	2	1	2
Tank	4	1	3	2	2	2	4
Boat	3	1	2	1	2	2	3
Aircraft Carrier	3	3	6	1	1	2	6
Plane	4	1	2	3	2	3	3
Bomber	5	1	3	2	2	2	5
Anti-Air Artillery	2	1	1	2	2	1	4

NATIONAL SETUP REFERENCE						
NATION	POP.	FACTORY	CITIES	TREASURY	WEAPON	UNITS
Germany	4	6	3 (2)	66	5	5
United Kingdom	3	4	3	40	4	4
France	3	3	3	30	3	3
Italy	2	2	2	20	2	2
Soviet Union	6	5	3 (2)	50	5	5
Poland	2	1	2	10	2	2
SE Europe	2	1	2	10	1	1
N. Europe	1	1	1	5	1	1
Iberian Pen.	1	1	1	5	1	1

NATION	POP.	FACTORY	CITIES	TREASURY	WEAPON	UNITS
China	5	2	3	20	3	3
Japan	4	5	3 (2)	50	5	5
South Africa	1	1	1	5	1	1
South America	2	1	2	10	1	1
Oceania	1	1	1	5	1	1
United States	5	6	3 (2)	60	5	5
Middle East	1	1	1	5	0	0
British India	3	2	2	15	2	2
Korea	1	1	1	5	1	1

SETUP MANUAL - FIELD REFERENCE

Figure 6. Rulebook and Reference Sheets

- Game Boards for Every Territory

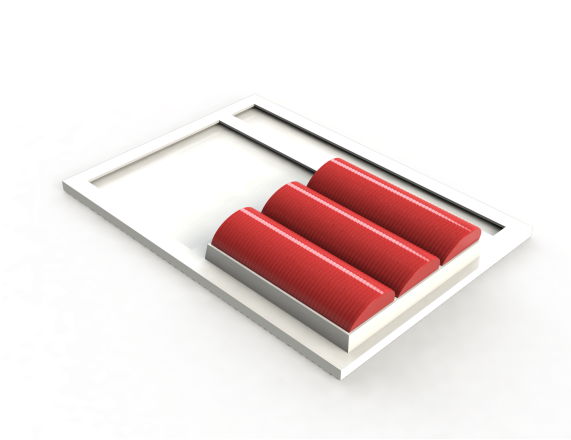


Figure 7. Gameboard Design

2. Overview

In *The Cruellest Years*, three to eighteen players assume command of the major powers of the Second World War between October 1935 and September 1945. Each player leads a nation through 120 turns of one month each, building factories, training armies, choosing between named historical leaders, and contesting forty-one territories across a global map. Every turn forces a choice between expanding your industrial base, raising new units, and pushing forward against your neighbours—and your decisions echo through the decade that followed.

The game opens with Italy's invasion of Ethiopia, the first act of the global war, and ends with the Japanese surrender or by victory at the table. The central question is the question the historical actors faced: can the will of a nation be matched by its resources, and can either of those things be matched by the appetite of its leaders?

The Cruellest Years is designed to be deeply asymmetric. The German player commands the most advanced factories in the world but has small territory; the Soviet player commands vast manpower but begins industrially behind Germany; the Chinese player begins poor and outnumbered but cannot easily be conquered. No two campaigns play the same way, and no nation has a single dominant strategy.

3. Objective

Victory in *The Cruellest Years* is by territorial domination. A player or team wins by controlling a sufficient number of territories at the moment the threshold is first crossed, or—if no one has crossed the threshold—by holding the most territory at the agreed end of the campaign.

Victory Thresholds

The world is divided into 41 territories. Each campaign may be played at the scale of the whole world, the European theatre alone, or the Asian theatre alone, or any combination of theatres agreed by the table.

Theatre	Total Territories	Solo Victory	Team Victory
World (full campaign)	41	21 / 41	28 / 41
European Theatre	21	12 / 21	15 / 21
Asian Theatre	11	6 / 11	8 / 11

Multi-Theatre Play

When a game spans more than one theatre, the thresholds for each theatre played are added together. A game covering both Europe and Asia requires 18 territories (12 + 6) for solo victory

or 23 territories (15 + 8) for team victory. Players may combine theatres in any pattern they like to construct a campaign of exactly the scale they want to play.

Draws & Tiebreakers

If two players or teams reach the threshold on the same turn, the player whose territories include the most cities wins. If still tied, the player with the higher combined total of treasury plus population wins. If still tied, the result stands as a shared victory.

4. Number of Players & Roles

Number of players: 3 to 18 players.

Players may play in teams: yes, optional. Teams may be declared formally at the start of the campaign and confirmed if all team members agree, or formed during play through diplomatic alliance. Team membership cannot be unilaterally broken once declared, but a former teammate may declare war on a former ally at the cost of a defined diplomatic penalty (see Glossary).

The Eighteen Playable Powers

The Cruellest Years offers eighteen playable powers. They are organised into three groupings by region. Each is an asymmetric role with its own starting resources, leader options, and Unique Unit Trait. A full statistical dossier appears in Section 7.

Europe (Nine Powers)

- **Germany**, The leading industrial power of continental Europe. Strong factory base, aggressive doctrine.
- **United Kingdom**, Naval-focused power with the strongest starting treasury in Europe and colonial holdings.
- **France**, Continental power with substantial treasury, balanced army, and colonial holdings.
- **Italy**, Mediterranean Axis power. Modest industry, mobile infantry, and the game's opening aggressor.
- **Soviet Union**, The largest manpower base in the game. Industrially behind at start but capable of explosive growth.
- **Poland**, Small but strategically pivotal. Located between Germany and the Soviet Union, with a strong home-front infantry doctrine.
- **Southeastern Europe**, Bloc representing the Balkans and Hungary. Cheap, fast partisan-style infantry.
- **Northern Europe**, Bloc representing the Nordic countries and Finland. Small population, large city network for income.
- **Iberian Peninsula**, Spain and Portugal. Officially neutral; rewarded for staying that way.

Asia (Two Powers)

- **China**, The largest manpower base in Asia. Industrially poor, but supports the Two Chinas variant (Section 7) for cooperative play.
- **Japan**, Industrial Axis power of the Pacific. Strong fleet, ranged aircraft, and the Kamikaze trait.

The Wider World (Seven Powers)

- **United States**, Strongest treasury in the game (66 gold), highest factory count (6), and the most efficient unit production.
- **South America**, Brazil, Argentina, and neighbours. Cheap mechanized doctrine.
- **South Africa**, African power. Strong defensive infantry.
- **Oceania**, Australia and New Zealand. Specialised in defensive infantry and naval support.
- **Middle East**, Turkey, Iran, and the Arabian peninsula. Oil-based treasury growth.
- **British India**, South Asia. Large population base; functions semi-independently of the United Kingdom.
- **Korea**, Korean Provisional Government and resistance movements. Begins under Japanese occupation and seeks liberation.

Whose Perspective is Included

The Cruellest Years was designed with an explicit choice to include not only the great powers but also smaller and occupied nations—Poland, Korea, the Iberian neutrals, the Nordic countries. This was a deliberate design decision because the histories of these powers are typically erased in wargames that focus only on the eight major belligerents. We chose to grant agency, at the table, to nations that historically had agency taken from them.

Even so, there are groups affected by the war who have no playable role here. The civilian populations of every nation; the colonised peoples of the Indian subcontinent, Southeast Asia, North Africa, and the Pacific who lived under foreign rule; the millions in the European Holocaust; the millions in the Pacific atrocities. Their experiences are not reducible to a player role. Our solution is to reference these histories in the Historical Events Deck (Section 6, in development) rather than to turn them into game pieces. We believe this is the more responsible design choice; we acknowledge it remains an imperfect one.

5. Setup

1. **Place the World Map in the centre of the table so that all players can reach their starting territories.**

2. **Choose nations.** Each player chooses one of the eighteen playable powers. With fewer than six players, give priority to the Great Powers (Germany, United Kingdom, France, Italy, Soviet Union, United States, China, Japan) before assigning regional powers. Unassigned nations are controlled by the rules (see Section 10, FAQ) or left neutral.
3. **Distribute starting resources.** Each player takes the gold, weapons, and population tokens listed in their nation's dossier (Section 7).
4. **Place starting cities and factories.** Each player places their starting cities and factories on the territories they control at the start. City and factory counts are listed in the dossier.
5. **Place starting units.** Each player places their starting military units (default Infantry) on their home territories. Players may exchange any Infantry for another unit of equal or lower weapon cost at no additional cost.
6. **Choose a leader.** Each nation has between one and three named historical leaders available (Section 7). Each player chooses one leader to govern with for the entire campaign. The choice is binding except through specific event cards.
7. **Determine first turn.** Italy takes the first turn of the game, in honour of the historical opening blow against Ethiopia. The Italian player flips a coin to determine the direction of play: heads for clockwise, tails for counter-clockwise.
8. **Begin Turn 1.** The Italian player begins the Income Phase.

Note on Starting Asymmetry

Players do not start with equal resources. This is a conscious design choice. In the autumn of 1935, the world's industrial, military, and economic strength was distributed extremely unevenly—the United States held over a hundred billion dollars in real assets while the Republic of China struggled to maintain a national army. The Cruellest Years preserves this asymmetry to teach what was at stake for each nation entering the war. Balance is provided not by equal starts but by the team-victory mechanic, the multi-region campaign system, and the asymmetric leader cards.

6. Gameplay

One turn represents one calendar month. A full campaign lasts 120 turns (October 1935 to September 1945). Each round consists of every player taking one turn in the direction established at game start.

Turn Direction & The Reversal Rule

Italy takes the first turn of the game. A coin flip determines clockwise (heads) or counter-clockwise (tails) play for the first round. At the start of every subsequent round, the

direction of play reverses. The last player of one round becomes the first player of the next. This prevents the same player from always reacting to the same neighbour, and it prevents end-of-round kingmaking.

The Four Phases of a Turn

On your turn, resolve the following four phases in order.

Phase 1—Income and Products

Collect the resources produced by every city and factory you currently control.

- Each city produces +5 gold and +1 population.
- Each factory produces +1 weapon.

If a city was captured from you on the previous turn, its income belongs to its current owner this turn.

Phase 2—Leader & Territorial Abilities

Resolve any abilities granted by your chosen leader card or by territorial features.

- Passive abilities are always active. They do not need to be declared and trigger automatically when their condition is met.
- Active abilities must be declared now. Pay the listed cost (gold, weapons, population, or other resource). Active abilities have a cooldown (CD), shown on the card, during which they cannot be triggered again. A cooldown of 1 means the ability can be triggered every other turn; a cooldown of 5 means once every five turns.
- Hybrid abilities combine a passive effect (always active) with an active component that may be declared during this phase.

Phase 3—Train Units

Choose which military units to recruit and where. Pay their weapon and population cost from your stockpile (see Section 7 unit table). Place an untrained marker on the figure. Newly trained units cannot move or attack on the turn they are recruited; they enter active service at the start of your next turn.

Phase 4—Move & Attack

Move and attack with units previously brought into active service.

- A unit's Speed is the maximum number of tiles it may move in this phase.
- A unit may attack after moving. It may not move after attacking, unless its leader ability or trait specifically permits.
- Each tile may contain only one military unit at a time. No stacking.

- When a unit is attacked, remove HP coins from beneath the unit equal to the attacker's Attack value. A unit with no HP coins remaining is destroyed and removed from the board.
- Range is the maximum normal distance between attacker and target. A commander may also attempt an over-range strike: declaring an attack against a target one tile beyond the unit's printed Range. To succeed, flip a coin. Heads: the strike hits normally. Tails: the strike misses, and the unit's action is spent. Over-range strikes cannot extend Range by more than one tile.
- Only Planes and Anti-Aircraft Artillery may target enemy aircraft. All other units must endure aerial bombardment without reply.

Historical Constraints Reflected in the Rules

Several rules in The Cruellest Years are direct expressions of historical constraint:

- **Italy starts first** because Italy historically launched the first major aggression of the global war (Ethiopia, October 1935). The order of belligerent action in our game is not arbitrary.
- **The reversal rule** reflects the historical fact that no power in WWII could plan permanently around its neighbours' moves. Initiative shifted as the war progressed.
- **Training takes one turn** because conscription and equipping a soldier was not instantaneous. Every army of the Second World War paid this cost in mobilisation time.
- **Aircraft Carriers cost six population** because in the historical record the construction and crewing of a major fleet carrier required tens of thousands of skilled labourers and sailors.
- **The over-range coin flip** represents the historical difficulty of striking accurately at the edge of a unit's effective range. The reach was possible; the hit was uncertain.

7. Special Abilities or Cards

List every special ability, power, or card effect in your game. For each one, name it, describe exactly what it does, and state when and how it can be used.

Detailed Abilities in:

Special Abilities or Cards Detailed Version

8. Game End

Trigger

The game ends at one of two moments, whichever occurs first:

1. A player or team reaches the victory threshold for the theatre(s) being played (see Section 3).
2. The campaign reaches its agreed end date. For a full campaign this is September 1945 (turn 120). For a theatre module it is the end-date listed for that scenario.

Resolution

When a player crosses the victory threshold during their own turn, the round continues to its end. If no other player crosses the threshold by the end of the round, the player who triggered the win is the victor. If multiple players cross during the same round, the player or team holding the most territories at the end of the round wins.

If the campaign ends by date rather than by victory, the player or team holding the most territories at that moment wins.

Tiebreakers

In order:

1. Most cities are controlled.
2. Highest combined total of treasury plus population.
3. Most military units in play.
4. Highest combined HP across all military units.
5. If all four are tied, the result stands as a shared victory.

Historical Resonance

The real Second World War did not end with a single victor and a clean line. Even on V-E Day (May 1945) and V-J Day (September 1945), the questions of who had won what, and at what cost to whom, were not fully settled. Some borders shifted again within a decade; some political settlements lasted only until the Cold War made them obsolete. The Cruellest Years preserves a measurable game outcome (territory held) while acknowledging in its design that historical victory was rarely complete and rarely clean. The team-victory option exists precisely to capture this—many of the war's true outcomes were shared by coalitions, not by lone victors.

9. Glossary

Terms used in this rulebook with specific game meanings. Definitions in alphabetical order.

Active Ability. A leader or trait ability that must be declared during the Leader Phase of a turn. Often has a cost (gold, weapons, population) and a cooldown (CD) in turns.

Adjacent. A territory or unit is adjacent to another if they share a border on the map.

Agenda Card. An optional strategic doctrine card. Each nation has three. In development.

Capital. One city in each nation, designated at game start, is the Capital. Most event and agenda cards reference the Capital, but losing it is not by itself a game-ending event.

City. A map structure that produces +5 gold and +1 population per turn. Cities are placed at game start; they cannot be moved or rebuilt.

Cooldown (CD). The number of turns a player must wait between uses of an active ability. A CD of 5 means the ability can be triggered once, then again five turns later. A CD of 1 means the ability can be triggered every other turn. A CD of 99 effectively limits the ability to once per game.

Diplomatic Penalty. The cost of breaking a declared alliance. A player who attacks a former teammate loses 10 gold and 1 weapon at the start of the turn the attack is declared.

Factory. A map structure that produces +1 weapon per turn. Factories may be built during play (see Section 6).

Fee. The per-turn maintenance cost of a military unit, listed in the unit table. A unit whose Fee cannot be paid is removed from the board at the end of the Income Phase.

Friendly Unit. Any unit belonging to you, or to a player on the same declared team as you.

Great Power. One of the eight powers that drove the war directly: Germany, United Kingdom, France, Italy, Soviet Union, United States, China, Japan.

HP Coin. A small marker placed beneath a unit figure to track its remaining HP. Each unit starts with HP coins equal to its HP value.

Hybrid Ability. A leader ability with both a passive component (always on) and an active component (declared on a turn).

KMT. Kuomintang—the Chinese Nationalist Party led by Chiang Kai-shek.

Over-Range Strike. An attempt to attack a target one tile beyond a unit's printed Range. Resolved by coin flip; heads hits, tails misses.

Passive Ability. A leader or trait ability that is always active. It does not need to be declared and triggers automatically whenever its condition is met.

Regional Power. A playable nation that is not one of the eight Great Powers. Smaller in starting statistics but distinguished by their leader cards and unit traits.

Theatre. A grouping of territories. The three theatres are Europe (21 territories), Asia (11 territories), and the Wider World (9 territories distributed across the Americas, Africa, Oceania, and the Middle East).

Trained / Untrained. A unit is untrained for the turn it is recruited. It cannot move or attack until its owner's next turn, at which point it becomes trained.

Two Chinas. An optional rule allowing China to be played as a single player, as two cooperating players (United Front), or as two semi-independent players (Civil Truce).

Unique Unit Trait. A passive modifier each nation applies to its standard military units. Listed under Section 7.3.

Wider World. The non-European and non-Asian theatres: the Americas, Africa, Oceania, and the Middle East.

10. FAQ & Edge Cases

Q: A player chose Italy because Italy goes first—is that a fair advantage?

Italy's first-move advantage is intentional and balanced by Italy's relatively small starting dossier. The first-move advantage in this game is modest, because every player gets income before the first attack can land. If your table feels Italy is overpowered after several plays, consider houseruling that Italy may not attack on Turn 1.

Q: Can a player decline to play a leader and use no leader ability?

No. Every player must choose one leader at setup. The leader's ability—passive or active—is in effect for the entire campaign.

Q: What happens if a player is eliminated mid-game (loses their capital and all cities)?

An eliminated player's territories become Neutral, removed from any player's control. The eliminated player may continue to participate as an Observer (rolling for events, offering counsel) but no longer takes turns. If a teammate of the eliminated player remains in play, the teammate may capture the eliminated player's former territories as if they were enemy territories.

Q: Can factories be built in captured territories?

Yes. Once you have held a territory for at least 3 consecutive turns, you may begin construction of new factories there subject to the usual cost and 3-per-territory cap.

Q: A unit's Range is 2, and I want to attack a target 3 tiles away. Can I attempt an over-range strike?

No. Over-range strikes may extend Range by only one tile. The maximum reach is Range + 1. There is no way to extend further in the streamlined edition.

Q: Two players' Boats attack each other. How is damage resolved?

Both units deal damage simultaneously. Subtract the attacker's Attack from the defender's HP coins, and the defender's Attack from the attacker's HP coins, in the same combat resolution. If both reach 0 HP, both are removed.

Q: When Japan uses the MXY-7 Sakura ability and the plane crashes, where does it land?

The crashing plane is removed from the board entirely. It does not damage any other unit on its way down. The +1 Attack applies only to the attack itself, not to any subsequent strike.

Q: Can a player who chose Hindenburg switch to Hitler later because Hitler became more useful?

No. The leader choice is binding for the entire campaign. The only way to change leaders is through a specific event card that explicitly grants the option (in development).

Q: A player runs out of weapons mid-turn. Can they still train units?

Only if they can pay the full weapon and population cost from their stockpile. Partial payment is not allowed. Players may carry weapons across turns; weapons are never lost to time.

Q: What happens when a unit's Fee cannot be paid at the end of the Income Phase?

The unit is removed from the board. The player chooses which units to remove if multiple units would be unsupported.

Q: A territory has 3 factories. Can a fourth be built if one is destroyed?

Yes. The 3-factory cap applies to the maximum number standing simultaneously. If one is destroyed, a replacement may be built subject to the normal cost and time.

Q: Are coin flips by a single player visible to other players?

Yes. All coin flips happen in the open. Hidden information in this game is limited to leader choice (until the first time the ability triggers) and the contents of the Agenda Deck.

11. Strategy Notes

These notes help new players understand the spirit of the game. They are not a guide to winning, only to playing thoughtfully.

On Opening Moves

The most common mistake is to attack too early. Income compounds in this game—every turn of peaceful production gives you more weapons and more population to spend later. A nation that spends its first ten turns building factories and stockpiling resources is usually stronger by Turn 15 than a nation that spends those turns conquering its neighbours. The historical analogy is real: the Soviet Union's productive recovery from 1941 onward, and the American mobilisation between 1939 and 1942, were both made possible by the willingness to wait. Build first; strike when you have the strength to follow through.

On Choosing a Leader

Read both (or all three) leader options before you choose. Aggressive abilities (Hitler's Total War, Mussolini's Battle for Grain) reward early expansion. Passive economic abilities (Hindenburg's War Bond, Stalin's Collectivization) reward patient building. The leader you pick should match the strategic shape of your nation and your appetite for early aggression.

On Alliances

Team victory is achievable at 28/41 (world scale), only 7 more than the solo threshold. Two players who form an early defensive pact and split a continent between them are often stronger

than two rivals fighting for the same continent. Diplomacy is not a sideshow in this game; it is a strategy.

On the History

Players who know the history will spot opportunities that less-informed players will miss. Why does Japan start with three factories but only one city? Because the historical Japanese empire was industrial out of proportion to its small home population. Why does the United States start with 66 gold? Because the historical American economy in 1935 was many times richer than any of its rivals. Why is China's population six but its treasury three? Because the Republic of China in 1935 had vast manpower and almost no money. Reading the dossiers as a history lesson, not just as numbers, will improve your play.

On the Spirit of the Game

The Cruellest Years is not a triumph game. There is no "good" path through it—every campaign ends with millions of imaginary lives spent for territory. Play it the way it was meant to be played: as a thoughtful, sometimes uncomfortable, examination of how the great powers of the 1930s made the choices that broke the modern world. Take the game seriously, and the history seriously, and you will play it well.

12. Credits

List everyone who contributed. Include designers, playtesters, and the historical sources that shaped your research.

Designed by: Leon, Jeff, Oliver, Larry

Playtested by: The design team and the course's playtest sessions.

Special thanks to: Mr. Solomon, Ms. Wang, Monsieur Roland, Mr. Tyler Crumrine

Course: Your Move: How Game Design Brings History to Life.

Historical sources:

The Cruellest Years draws on a body of academic and popular historical scholarship on the Second World War. The full bibliography follows below, formatted in the Chicago Manual of Style (notes and bibliography system). Particular thanks to the following for shaping the design of specific national dossiers and leader cards:

- Antony Beevor, for the operational and human texture of the European campaigns.
- Rana Mitter, for the perspective that reshaped our treatment of China as a major belligerent rather than a Pacific sideshow.
- Timothy Snyder, for the unsettling reframe of the European war as a contest over the lives of civilians, not only the borders of states.

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